



Dastana forearm guard
Date unknown

Forearm guards (*dastanas*) were worn by Mughal warriors to shield limbs from glancing blows. The hinged plate also protected the inner arm surface.

elbow protector



Metal turban helmet
Date unknown

The warriors of early Mughal armies wore lightweight but effective turban helmets with nose and neck guards to deflect enemy arrows and blades.

sliding bar for nose protection



Battle-ax
17th century

Mughal ideals of beauty extended even to weapons, such as this ornate but formidable cavalryman's ax from India's Deccan region.

elaborate tip

Spiked parrying shield
18th century

With its five spikes and central plate, this Mughal device served as an elaborate and dangerously impressive weapon, as well as vital protection for its bearer.

each blade is 7 in (17.7 cm) long

central plate

MUGHAL EMPIRE

OUT OF A POWER STRUGGLE EMERGED AN ADVANCED, WEALTHY, AND INTEGRATED SOCIETY

For over two centuries (1526–1761), Mughal rulers dominated most of India. Through military might and administrative prowess, they integrated Hindus and Muslims into a rich culture of imperial splendor.

With their roots in Mongol and Turkish cultures, seven generations of Mughal kings, beginning with Babur (r. 1526–30), blended Persian and Islamic military and artistic influences into India's indigenous Hindu culture. The result was one of the most impressive medieval empires, which, at its height (1556–1707), commanded vast wealth, assimilated Hindus into its ruling elite, expanded education, and provided patronage in the arts and literature.



antelope features carved in ivory

Ivory priming powder horn
Date unknown

Ivory carving had an ancient history in India, and it became equally revered in Mughal courts. This powder horn, used on hunts, has an antelope shape.



silk embroidery in chain stitches

Hunt painting
17th century

Hunting and horsemanship were favorite pastimes of Mughal rulers, who created huge hunting parks. A prince is seen here on horseback with a servant and hound.

fleeing antelope

deer being hunted



servant with hound

Satin hunting jacket
Early 17th century

The sport of kings required beautifully adorned clothing—this coat is lavishly embroidered with typically Persian floral patterns.



Mughal miniature
Date unknown

Arts and architecture flourished under the patronage of Mughal kings such as Akbar (r. 1542–1605). Miniature painting, introduced as manuscript illustration, was most prized.